

Accessibility review: National History Museum

****Observer:**** Olivia Lombardo

****Date:**** 2026-05-11

****Overall compliance:**** 63% of rated items met (10 met, 0 not met, 6 partial, 1 N/A)

Exhibits & objects

-  Small objects mounted at or below 40 in. (seated eye level) — ****Met****
-  Display cases shallow enough to see objects from above — ****Met****
 - > Some of the little description cards in the cases were flat versus tilted. I felt that tilted was better for those who are lower to the ground. If your eye level was at the case it would be hard to read.
-  Objects have 70% color contrast against their background — ****Met****
 - > The stands the objects were displayed against seemed to have fair contrast. There were not all standard white and varied based on the item.
-  Touchable objects or reproductions available for tactile access — ****N/A****
 - > Majority of the items were in cases and not to be touched.
-  Audio description provided for items that cannot be touched — ****Partial****
 - > Only some of the displays had audio options. It seemed that the audio was for those who wanted additional information and not provided at all for exhibits with written descriptions. Written plaques were only offered in English/Irish.
-  No objects protrude more than 4 in. from walls at head height — ****Met****
-  No low floor-level objects that could be tripping hazards — ****Met****
 - > Some exhibits had rugs, but I seemed to be stuck to the ground so they wouldn't roll up and become a tripping hazard.
-  At least 100 lux of light on displayed objects — ****Partial****
 - > For the most part I felt lighting was not a big issue. There were some rooms with items that are light sensitive so it would definitely fall below this threshold for preservation reasons.

Pathways & navigation

-  Main circulation route at least 36 in. wide (60 in. preferred) — ****Partial****
 - > The majority of the big exhibits were definitely 36in wide, but the smaller more specialized exhibit rooms were narrower. The second floor had many tight spaces and sharper turns.
-  At least 80 in. of clear overhead clearance throughout — ****Met****
-  Route is step-free, or ramps/lifts provided at level changes — ****Partial****
 - > Again, many of the specialized rooms had awkward stairs and partial floor levels. A good example is the Egyptian room.
-  Floor surface is stable, firm, and slip-resistant — ****Met****
-  Route well lit (50–100 lux) with no confusing shadow pools — ****Partial****
 - > The main spaces are well lit. Exceptions are the rooms that are meant for items that are light sensitive.

-  70% color contrast between floor and walls/furniture — ****Met****
 -  Accessible floor map available at the gallery entrance — ****Met****
 - > There were pamphlets at the room and many areas that had a floor plan on the wall or stand.
 -  More than one exit from the exhibition — ****Met****
 -  60 in. wheelchair turning space at any dead ends — ****Partial****
 - > The smaller rooms to the side were much narrower and would become crammed very easily.
- It would be difficult for a wheelchair to navigate especially on floor 2.

Checklist based on the [Smithsonian Guidelines for Accessible Exhibition Design](<https://www.sifacilities.si.edu/sites/default/files/Files/Accessibility/accessible-exhibition-design1.pdf>)